It is obvious that Pathania had already mentally lost the battle for Se-la. Despite having tried his best to get a formal sanction to withdraw 4 Division, he did not have the mandate to pull 62 Brigade out at that point; on the contrary, he was repeatedly being told to stay put. In the long drawn-out conversations, the GOC began to paint a picture that was not quite true. On the other hand, he started undermining the confidence of Hoshiar Singh. If indeed Pathania was so rattled by the Chinese having cut the road behind him, the logical thing for him to have done would have been to collect 65 Infantry Brigade and marry up with 62 Brigade and fight it out with the Chinese. By closing the gap towards Senge Dzong (Pathania also had tanks from 7 Cavalry with him) he could have watched Hoshiar's Singh's back, making sure that air supply would not be affected. The Chinese who could attack from the rear were unlikely to have any artillery. Meanwhile, 48 Brigade would have been left to fight a defensive battle against the Chinese who had come over Poshing-la and other routes. Reinforced by 67 Infantry Brigade, the push towards Se-la for the relief of 62 and 65 Brigade would have stretched the Chinese troops and caught them in a trap of their own making.

Had Pathania moved forward instead of backwards, the story may well have turned out very differently. This did not require any brilliant thinking on the part of the higher command—it was the original concept in the first place in any case. It had got derailed when Pathania had decided to locate his Division HQ at Dirang rather than at Senge. However, it was pretty obvious by then that no one was thinking straight anymore.

Pathania would later claim that he did not 'order' Hoshiar Singh to withdraw, he merely asked him to prepare a withdrawal plan for the night of 17-18 November. Though Hoshiar Singh has come under criticism for agreeing to pull back, it is pretty obvious from existing records that the brigade commander was bullied into accepting Pathania's orders.

IV CORPS HQ (17 NOVEMBER - EVENING)

In his usual dramatic style, Kaul entered the IV Corps Ops Room at 7 p.m. Through the day the corps commander had been at Walong where remnants of 6 Kumaon and 4 Sikh had been trying to fall back along the almost non-existent track towards the Assam plains. Despite the defeat suffered in the Lohit Frontier Division, Kaul was in an upbeat mood. Full of the day's events, the corps commander did not notice the grim faces and the tension